

Chelonoidis carbonarius

Red-footed tortoise



Length 16–20 in (40–50 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Central and South America



The genus *Chelonoidis* includes the world's biggest tortoises, as well as many smaller species, such as this one from South America. Its

reddish edge to forelimb

legs are marked with splashes of red or yellowish orange, and the shell—in adult males—is unusually elongated, with a constriction in the middle. Like most of its relatives, the red-footed tortoise lives mainly on plant food, such as leaves and fallen fruit, but it also scavenges animal remains. Females lay clutches of 2–15 nearly spherical eggs several times a year.

growth rings on scutes
reddish or yellow blotch on scutes



Geochelone elegans

Indian starred tortoise



Length Up to 11 in (28 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location S. Asia



With its star-shaped markings and knobby carapace, this Asian species is one of the world's most distinctive tortoises. Each of its scutes rises to a rounded point, and the carapace as

a whole is strongly domed. The Indian starred tortoise needs plenty of water, and it is most active during the monsoon season. In drier weather, it stirs only in the morning and late afternoon. Each year, the female lays several clutches of up to 10 eggs in a flask-shaped chamber 4–6 in (10–15 cm) deep.

scutes rising to rounded points
yellowish brown lines radiating to edge of scutes



Stigmochelys pardalis

Leopard tortoise



Length 12–28 in (30–70 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location E. to southern Africa



The carapace of the leopard tortoise is yellowish, with scattered dark markings that are bolder, although fewer, in hatchlings. In some individuals, it can grow to 28 in (70 cm) long. This tortoise lives in a

variety of habitats, from sandy, coastal scrub to grassland and semidesert, although it is scarce in very dry deserts. It may bury itself to hibernate in cool parts of its range, and to estivate in the hotter parts. The leopard tortoise is herbivorous, grazing on grasses, fallen fruit, fungi, and the leaves of succulents. In the breeding season, the female digs a flask-shaped pit with her hind feet, urinating to soften hard soil, and lays 3–6 clutches of 5–30 eggs at monthly intervals. Hatchlings may have to wait in the nest chamber for several weeks for rain to soften the ground before they can burrow to the surface. The young become prey to monitor lizards, storks, crows, and small mammals.

growth rings on scutes
scattered dark markings

domed carapace with vertical sides



Gopherus agassizii

Desert tortoise



Length 10–14 in (25–36 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico



This tortoise's thick, shovel-shaped forefeet are specially adapted for digging burrows in which to escape the extreme heat of the desert during the day and the cold at night. It shelters individually in burrows in very hot or drought conditions but may gather in large, communal dens dug into gravel banks to escape the cold. It lives for at least 50 years, mainly eating cacti and grasses, but also feeds on insects. Males have longer projections at the front of their plastrons and may attack each other on sight in the breeding season.

sculptured plates
heavily built, domed carapace



Kinixys erosa

Serrated hinge-back tortoise



Length 10–12½ in (25–32 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiterrestrial
Status Data deficient

Location W. to C. Africa



A hinge toward the back of the carapace enables this tortoise to shut itself in its shell completely. A fair swimmer, it seeks out marshes

Homopus signatus

Speckled padloper



Length 2¼–3¼ in (6–8 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Near threatened

Location W. South Africa



This African species is the smallest tortoise in the world, with males being particularly tiny. Their small size makes speckled padlopers vulnerable to carnivorous mammals and birds, but it also enables them to squeeze under rocks to escape attack, and to shelter from the sun. The flattened shell is brown, orange-red, or salmon-pink, with fine black markings. Speckled padlopers live in dry habitats, and forage for small, succulent plants.

and riverbanks in its forest habitat, but when on land, it spends much of the time buried beneath roots and logs. It is an omnivorous species, feeding on plants, fruit, and invertebrates, as well as carrion. In a breeding season, females lay several clutches of up to 4 eggs on the ground, covering them with leaves.

hinged carapace
flared marginal scutes



Malacochersus tornieri

Pancake tortoise



Length 5½–6½ in (14–17 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location E. Africa



The carapace of this tortoise is not only extremely flat but also very flexible, due to openings in the underlying bones. This allows the tortoise to squeeze into narrow crevices in order to escape predatory mammals or birds; it can also

wedge itself in, for safety, by digging in its foreclaws and rotating the forelimbs, making extraction difficult. It forages, mainly in the mornings, for grasses, leaves, and fruit, but never moves far from the rocky outcrop in which it spends the night. In summer, this tortoise crawls under a flat stone and estivates to avoid the heat. Females lay several clutches of a single egg throughout the breeding season.

elongated, yellow to tan carapace

